

Pre-Writing Strategies

Pre-writing is an informal process that allows you to explore ideas as they occur to you. As you go, you don't have to relate them to anything else or worry about organization or mechanics.

There are six main strategies for getting started on any writing assignment:

- 1. Free writing /Focused Free writing**
- 2. Brainstorming/ mind-mapping**
- 3. Clustering**
- 4. Questioning**
- 5. Outlining**

Free Writing

Freewriting all by itself, is writing freely to meet a set parameter, usually a time length (ex. 15 minutes) or a page length (ex. one page). Even if what is written seems unrelated, disorganized, or incomplete, jot down any ideas that come to mind in what is called a stream of consciousness.

Very importantly, you do not stop for any reason; just keep writing. This is most useful when you are writing creatively and are looking to get started.

Focused free writing, just as with free writing, is writing for a specific length of time or a particular page length, paying no attention to spelling, grammar, organization, etc. Keep writing until you meet the set parameter, except this approach involves writing about a set topic. Because there is a particular focus, this method is much more helpful when there is a specific assignment that needs to be targeted. Even if you think you know nothing about the topic or find it uninteresting, you can use this strategy to create ideas about what you think the topic means or involves, or even imagine a story about the topic to make it relevant to you.

Sample

How would I use it?

Try this: Think or write "I am..." then write as much as you can.

- ♣ *I am a student (or fill in your occupation).*
- ♣ *I am a daughter/son/brother/sister/mom/dad/aunt/uncle/cousin/etc.*
- ♣ *I am an Eagle's fan.*
- ♣ *I am an animal lover.*

Write down all of the things associated with that part of yourself. Allow your ideas to flow, even if they become unrelated to the original idea. Apply this same concept to an assignment that you happen to be stuck on. Keep in mind that this is a first draft so if you feel like you are "getting off track," it is perfectly fine. Revisions will come later down the line. The important part here is to get some ideas on the paper.

Brainstorming

What is it? Brainstorming is creating a list of ideas in response to a problem or question. Similar to free writing, the ideas generated by brainstorming don't need to be related to each other; they only need to be related to the problem at hand. This technique can be done in a group or by yourself.

How would I use it?

There are two main ways of brainstorming:

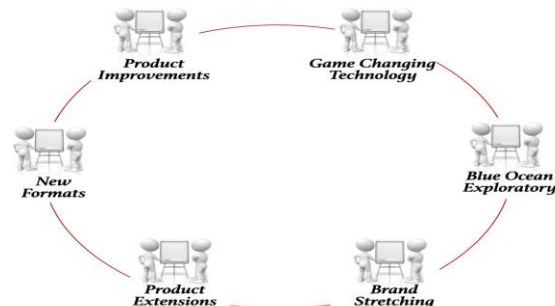
- 1. Posing and answering questions about a problem or topic:** Who? What? Where? When? Why? How?
- 2. Gathering a list of ideas related to the problem or topic.** For example, if you are brainstorming about your favorite food, you would make a list of all the sensory information about that food. What does it look, feel, taste, smell, and sound like? From there, you could list how it became your favorite food, the

events with which it is associated, how you prepare it, etc. Soon enough, you'll have a robust amount of information, and you'll be able to indulge in that food as a reward for your excellent brainstorming!

For example, if the main topic is “apples”:
My favorite type-Honey Crisp See-pinkish red skin with some orangey yellow mixed in, it is shiny.
Feel- smooth skinned Sound (when bitten)-there is a snap when teeth pierce the skin and then a crunch. Etc....

Sample

How to use Brainstorming to find new product ideas



Brainstorming Rules

Focus on quantity
The greater the number of ideas generated, the greater the chance of producing a radical and effective solution.

No criticism
Instead of immediately stating what might be wrong with an idea, the participants focus on extending or adding to it

Unusual ideas are welcome
They open new ways of thinking and provide better solutions than regular ideas.

Combine and improve ideas
This approach leads to better and more complete ideas than merely generating new ideas alone

Questioning Strategy

This is a basic strategy, useful at many levels, that helps you jot down the basic important information about a topic.

QUESTIONING STRATEGY IN ACTION

Explore the answers created for the topic: *What is the impact of traditional ecological knowledge on environmental management?*

Who? The Dene and Kessi tribes from two different ecosystems were impacted by European colonizers and their fire management policies.

What? Consider the impact of fire on the peoples in both environments.

Where? Canadian policies and historical data compared to African policies and historical data.

When? As far back as the last ice age, there is evidence of how fire has impacted the land. I will focus on the impact of colonization and the policies that affected the land management practices of the indigenous peoples. I will also consider the current implications of controlling and preventing fires.

Why? This information is important because the knowledge from the indigenous peoples and their traditional practices provides important insights into how to improve current fire practices.

How? Look at historical and current records, such as Lewis, Wuerthner, Fairhead and Leach . . .

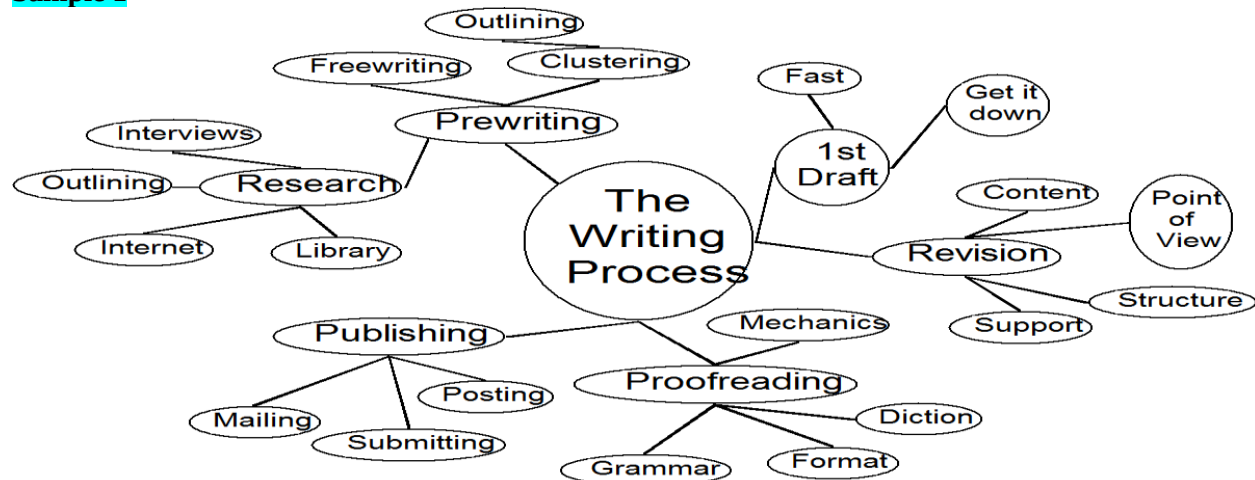
Note: Notice how this series of questions and answers is more developed than the same topic explored previously in Freewriting. This author has done a bit of preliminary reading on the subject between the two prewriting activities. This helps illustrate how prewriting can be useful to return to, even after later stages of the writing process.

Clustering

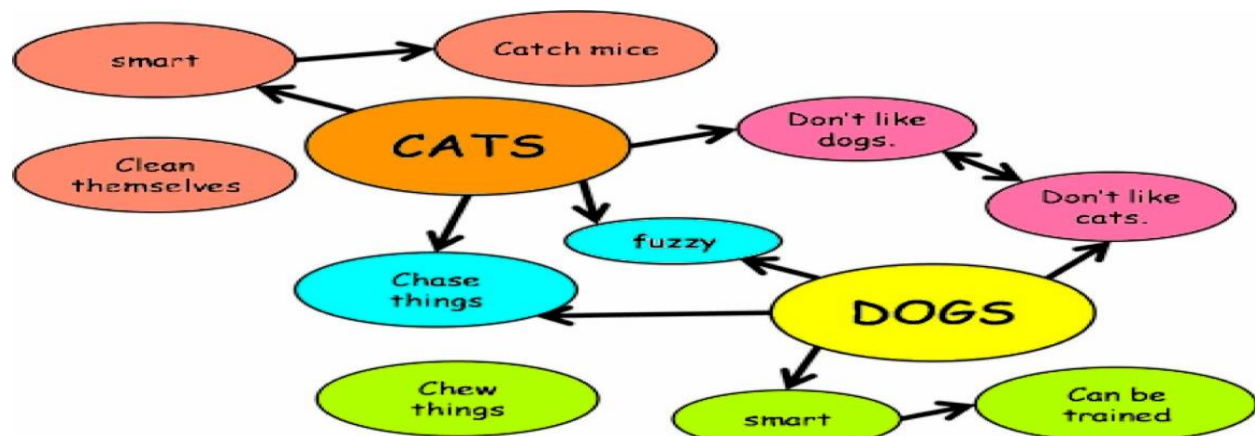
What is it?

Clustering utilizes a visual map to shape ideas and explore how those ideas relate to each other. Helpful tip: There are easy and free online tools for clustering that format your ideas as you go. How would I use it? When you cluster, your topic goes in a bubble in the middle of the page. From there, your ideas expand to form a spider-web visual. See below for an example.

Sample 1



Sample 2



Outlining

What is outlining in writing?

An outline is a general plan of the material that is to be presented in a speech or a paper. The outline shows the order of the various topics, the relative importance of each, and the relationship between the various parts. Order in an Outline. There are many ways to arrange the different parts of a subject.

Sample 1

Outline	
I. Intro	
II. First point	
A. Detail	
B. Detail	
C. Detail	
III. Second point	
A. Detail	
B. Detail	
C. Detail	
D. Detail	
IV. Third point	
A. Detail	
B. Detail	
C. Detail	
V. Conclusion	

Sample 2

Alphanumeric Outline

THE COLLEGE APPLICATION PROCESS	
I. CHOOSE DESIRED COLLEGES	
A. Visit and evaluate college campuses	
B. Visit and evaluate college websites	
1. Look for interesting classes	
2. Note important statistics	
II. PREPARE APPLICATION	
A. Write personal statement	
1. Choose interesting topic	
a. Describe an influential person in your life	
(1) Favorite high school teacher	
(2) Grandparent	
b. Describe a challenging life event	
2. Include important personal details	
a. Volunteer work	
b. Participation in varsity sports	

Practice Activity

Use questioning strategy as a prewriting activity for gathering ideas on the topic given below:

What do you think why economy of Pakistan is going down? See questioning strategy in Pre-writing strategies.

Draw clustering on the following topic:

Importance of Time management for (academic/ daily life)

The importance of Recycling Objects

List in bullet points or draw a brainstorming/ mind-mapping on the topic given below:

Advantages and Disadvantages of Online Education

FACT AND OPINION

A fact is a statement that can be tested by experimentation, observation, or research and shown to be true or untrue. An opinion is a person's belief, feeling, or judgment about something. It is a subjective or value judgment, and it cannot be proven. A writer may use factual statements to support his or her opinions. Opinion statements may occur even in what seems to be strictly factual material. A reader should look for words that are clues to statements of opinion. Words such as perhaps sometimes probably often indicate the possibility of opinions. Words such as: I feel, I think, I believe (clearly points out that an opinion is being expressed)

EXERCISE 1: Write F on the line in front of each factual statement.

1. Harry S. Truman was a president of the United States. ____
2. Truman was one of the best presidents the United States has had. ____
3. Movies are generally more interesting than books. ____
4. The unemployment rate in the U.S. today is higher than it was in 1935. ____
5. Non-poisonous snakes make delightful pets. ____
6. Business sets outrageously high prices on its products. ____
7. Time is a better magazine than Newsweek. ____
8. The junior college is a better place to attend school for the first two years than is a university or a 4-year college. ____
9. In Arizona, smoking in public places is against the law. ____
10. Nicotine in cigarette smoke makes the heart beat faster . ____
11. Gold was discovered in California in 1848.
12. Charles Dickens' fascinating novel A Tale of Two Cities was published in 1840.
13. Israel and Egypt will never have a permanent peace settlement.
14. There is currently a shortage of science teachers in the state of Florida.
15. In 1970, over 30,000 children were enrolled in day-care programs in Miami-Dade County.

EXERCISE II: Mark statements of fact with an F and statements of opinion with an O.

1. In 1924, the Model T Ford could be purchased for \$290. ____
2. The Model T was the most important invention of the first half of the century.
3. By the end of this century, electric cars will be in common use.
4. Couples should be acquainted for at least a year before getting married.
5. Joining the Army is the best way to learn job skill.
6. No symbol elicits fear as does the swastika.
7. The core of a pencil is made of graphite and clay, not lead.
8. It's better to plant masses of flowers all in one color than in two or three colors.
9. The equator is 24,901.55 miles long.
10. It's never too early to teach children how to behave.